ANKYRA

Discussion Sheet

The same four questions for any passage. Use it with a small group or on your own. Print it, or type straight into it on a phone or laptop.

DATE

PASSAGE

Read the passage twice before saying anything about it: in a group, out loud, by two different people; on your own, slowly.

1. What happens?

Say it back in your own words. Nobody gets this wrong.

2. What does it show us about God?

Father, Son, Spirit. Stay in the passage.

3. What does it show us about people?

About them, and about us. Honest rather than polite.

4. So what do we do about it?

Something specific. This week, not one day.

Anything you didn't understand?

Write it down. Nobody is expected to understand all of it.

ONE THING I WILL DO THIS WEEK

If you're leading a group

FOR WHOEVER HAS THE SHEET THIS TIME

You do not need to know more than anyone else in the room. Your job is to ask the question and then stop talking. That is all of it.

On your own? The same shape works: read the passage twice, take the four questions in order, write down one thing, and pray about it.

Before

Read the passage twice during the week. That is the whole preparation. Do not write a talk: arrive with answers ready and you will end up delivering them, and everyone else will stop thinking.

A shape that works

10 min	Catch up. How has the week actually been?
5 min	Read the passage out loud, twice, two different voices.
30 min	The four questions, in order.
10 min	One thing each, then pray.

While you are leading

- **Ask, then wait.** Count to ten in your head. It will feel far longer than it is. Someone will speak.
- **If an answer is not in the passage, do not correct it.** Ask "whereabouts do you see that?" and let the text sort it out.
- **If you do not know, say so.** Write the question down and find out before next time, or ask someone who will know.
- **Do not let one person answer everything,** including you. Do not skip question four: a study that never changes anything turns into a hobby.

When it goes wrong

- **It goes quiet.** That is people thinking, not the study failing.
- **It drifts off.** "Good, let's come back to the passage." No apology needed.
- **Someone opens up about something heavy.** Stop the study. The passage will keep. Listen, and pray with them before they leave.

THE POINT

Not to get through the passage. It is that everyone leaves knowing something true about God that they did not know when they arrived, and one thing they are going to do about it.

Mark, in twenty-four sittings

IF YOU NEED A PASSAGE, WORK DOWN THIS LIST

Mark is the shortest Gospel and the fastest moving. It was almost certainly the first written, it assumes you know nothing, and it puts the question of who Jesus is in front of you within a page. One passage a week gets you through a whole Gospel in about six months.

1 · Mark 1:1–20
John the Baptist; Jesus baptised; four called

2 · Mark 1:21–45
A day in Capernaum, and a man with leprosy

3 · Mark 2:1–17
Forgiving sins; calling a tax collector

4 · Mark 2:18–3:6
Sabbath arguments; the first plot

5 · Mark 3:7–35
The Twelve chosen; opposition grows

6 · Mark 4:1–34
Parables: sower, lamp, mustard seed

7 · Mark 4:35–5:20
The storm calmed; the man among the tombs

8 · Mark 5:21–43
Two desperate people, one long wait

9 · Mark 6:1–29
Rejected at home; the Twelve sent; John killed

10 · Mark 6:30–56
Five thousand fed; a walk on the water

11 · Mark 7:1–30
What actually makes a person unclean

12 · Mark 7:31–8:21
More bread, and still not seeing it

13 · Mark 8:22–38
“Who do you say I am?” and the cost

14 · Mark 9:1–29
Transfigured; a father’s honest prayer

15 · Mark 9:30–50
Who is the greatest?

16 · Mark 10:1–31
Marriage, children, and money

17 · Mark 10:32–52
Serving rather than ruling; blind Bartimaeus

18 · Mark 11:1–33
Into Jerusalem; the temple cleared

19 · Mark 12:1–44
Traps, questions, and a widow’s two coins

20 · Mark 13:1–37
What is coming, and staying awake

21 · Mark 14:1–52
The last supper; Gethsemane; the arrest

22 · Mark 14:53–72
On trial, while Peter denies him

23 · Mark 15:1–47
Crucified

24 · Mark 16:1–8
The empty tomb

Two notes

Mark 16:9. Most Bibles put a note here. The earliest and most reliable copies of Mark end at verse 8; the last twelve verses appear only in later ones. Translators flag it rather than hide it: a good example of nothing being kept from you.

After Mark. Acts, to see how the church began. Then a short letter, Ephesians or Philippians, a few verses at a time, since the letters are denser than the Gospels.

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